C2 Vocabulary

Shades of meaning: from mild to strong

Choose the exact word on a scale of intensity, so your English says precisely what you mean.

At C2, accuracy means choosing the word with the right strength. *Annoyed*, *irritated* and *livid* all describe anger, but they paint very different pictures. Learn synonyms as ladders, from mildest to strongest.

annoyed → exasperated → livid adjective

angry, from mild to extreme

She was livid when the flight was cancelled for the third time.

concerned → anxious → distraught adjective

worried, from mild to overwhelming

The family was distraught after the accident.

pleased → delighted → elated adjective

happy, from mild to intense

He was elated to win the scholarship.

tired → exhausted → drained adjective

lacking energy, ending in complete emptiness

After the night shift she felt completely drained.

dislike → detest → loathe verb

not like, from mild to intense hatred

I loathe waiting in queues.

glance → look → stare → gaze verb

ways of looking: quick, neutral, fixed and rude, long and thoughtful

She gazed at the sea for hours.

chuckle → laugh → roar verb

laughing, from quiet to very loud

The audience roared at the final joke.

slim → thin → skinny → emaciated adjective

not fat, from positive to worrying

"Slim" is a compliment; "skinny" usually is not.

Watch the connotation too. Words at the same strength can be positive or negative: *slim* praises, *skinny* criticises; *thrifty* praises, *stingy* criticises.

Common mistake. Using intensifiers with already strong words: *very livid* or *very delighted* sound wrong. Use *absolutely* or *utterly*: *absolutely livid*, *utterly exhausted*.

Practice

1. Order from mildest to strongest: elated, pleased, delighted.
2. Choose: After the marathon she was absolutely (tired / exhausted).
3. Choose the positive word: (slim / skinny).
4. Replace *very angry* with one stronger word: The manager was very angry about the data leak.
5. Which verb suggests looking for a long time, thoughtfully? (glance / stare / gaze)

▼ **Show answers**

1. pleased, delighted, elated
2. exhausted
3. slim
4. livid / furious (The manager was livid about the data leak.)
5. gaze